

Cobalt Basin Mining Ltd — On-Site Audit Report

Facility:	Kolwezi processing facility and affiliated artisanal collection points, Democratic Republic of the Congo
Audit type:	Unannounced audit — site visit, subcontractor review, community interviews
Audit dates:	2026-04-07 to 2026-04-10 (4 days)
Auditor:	Meridian Assurance Partners (third-party), with independent environmental lab (Corelab DRC)
Overall rating:	Unsatisfactory — High Risk

Executive Summary

This unannounced audit identified critical non-conformances in labor, environmental, and chain-of-custody practices connected to Cobalt Basin Mining Ltd's artisanal supply chain. Given the severity of the labor findings, the auditor recommends immediate suspension of sourcing from the implicated subcontractor pending independent investigation.

Labor Practices

Auditors observed individuals who appeared to be between 14 and 16 years old working at two artisanal mineral collection points that feed into Cobalt Basin's supply chain via the subcontractor Kivu Mineral Aggregators. Age-verification documentation requested from the subcontractor for workers at these sites was incomplete for the majority of the roughly 60 workers observed, and the documentation that was provided contained internal inconsistencies (mismatched names and dates of birth across different records for the same individual).

Health & Safety

Shallow hand-dug shafts at the collection points inspected had inadequate or no shoring to prevent collapse. No records of personal protective equipment distribution to artisanal workers at these sites could be produced by the subcontractor.

Environmental

Independent laboratory analysis of a tailings pond discharge sample collected on 2026-04-08 found cobalt and copper concentrations exceeding the facility's environmental permit limits (see lab results table below).

Chain of Custody

Traceability documentation linking artisanal collection points to the Kolwezi processing facility could not be fully verified for approximately 18% of the lots sampled during the audit, meaning material from unverified or non-audited collection points may be entering the supply chain without detection.

Environmental Lab Results — Tailings Pond Discharge (2026-04-08)

Parameter	Result	Permit Limit	Status
Cobalt (dissolved)	3.8 mg/L	1.0 mg/L	Exceeds limit
Copper (dissolved)	2.1 mg/L	1.5 mg/L	Exceeds limit

Parameter	Result	Permit Limit	Status
pH	6.9	6.0–9.0	Within limit

Conclusion

Recommendation: certification is suspended effective immediately. Sourcing from Kivu Mineral Aggregators should be paused pending an independent investigation into the age-verification findings. A full re-audit is required before certification can be reinstated; no timeline is proposed until the labor investigation concludes.